(McCullagh and Nelder, 1989). Note, however, that in contrast to the models used for regression, they are no longer linear in the parameters due to the presence of the nonlinear function $f(\cdot)$. This will lead to more complex analytical and computational properties than for linear regression models. Nevertheless, these models are still relatively simple compared to the more general nonlinear models that will be studied in subsequent chapters.

The algorithms discussed in this chapter will be equally applicable if we first make a fixed nonlinear transformation of the input variables using a vector of basis functions $\boldsymbol{\phi}(\mathbf{x})$ as we did for regression models in Chapter 3. We begin by considering classification directly in the original input space $\mathbf{x}$, while in Section 4.3 we shall find it convenient to switch to a notation involving basis functions for consistency with later chapters.

4.1. Discriminant Functions

A discriminant is a function that takes an input vector $\mathbf{x}$ and assigns it to one of K classes, denoted $\mathcal{C}_k$. In this chapter, we shall restrict attention to *linear discriminants*, namely those for which the decision surfaces are hyperplanes. To simplify the discussion, we consider first the case of two classes and then investigate the extension to $K > 2$ classes.

4.1.1 Two classes

The simplest representation of a linear discriminant function is obtained by taking a linear function of the input vector so that

$$y(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{w}^{\mathrm{T}}\mathbf{x} + w_0 \tag{4.4}$$

where $\mathbf{w}$ is called a *weight vector*, and w_0 is a *bias* (not to be confused with bias in the statistical sense). The negative of the bias is sometimes called a *threshold*. An input vector $\mathbf{x}$ is assigned to class $\mathcal{C}_1$ if $y(\mathbf{x}) \geqslant 0$ and to class $\mathcal{C}_2$ otherwise. The corresponding decision boundary is therefore defined by the relation $y(\mathbf{x}) = 0$, which corresponds to a $(D-1)$-dimensional hyperplane within the D-dimensional input space. Consider two points $\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{A}}$ and $\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{B}}$ both of which lie on the decision surface. Because $y(\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{A}}) = y(\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{B}}) = 0$, we have $\mathbf{w}^{\mathrm{T}}(\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{A}} - \mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{B}}) = 0$ and hence the vector $\mathbf{w}$ is orthogonal to every vector lying within the decision surface, and so $\mathbf{w}$ determines the orientation of the decision surface. Similarly, if $\mathbf{x}$ is a point on the decision surface, then $y(\mathbf{x}) = 0$, and so the normal distance from the origin to the decision surface is given by

$$\frac{\mathbf{w}^{\mathrm{T}}\mathbf{x}}{\|\mathbf{w}\|} = -\frac{w_0}{\|\mathbf{w}\|}. \tag{4.5}$$

We therefore see that the bias parameter w_0 determines the location of the decision surface. These properties are illustrated for the case of $D = 2$ in Figure 4.1.

Furthermore, we note that the value of $y(\mathbf{x})$ gives a signed measure of the perpendicular distance r of the point $\mathbf{x}$ from the decision surface. To see this, consider

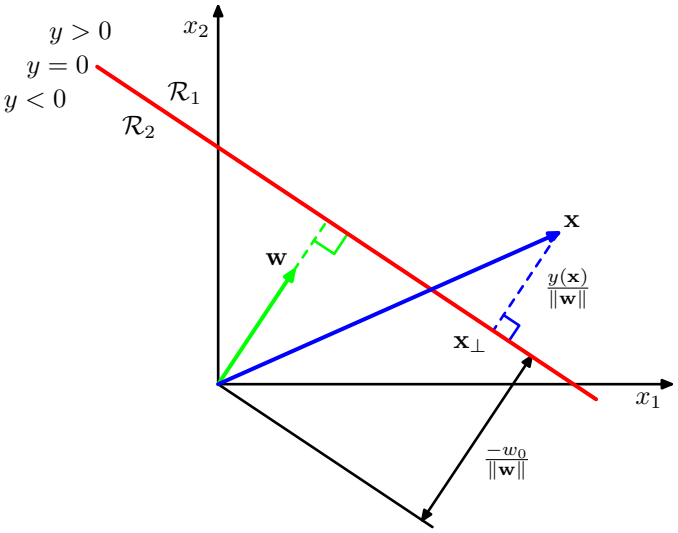


Figure 4.1 Illustration of the geometry of a linear discriminant function in two dimensions. The decision surface, shown in red, is perpendicular to $\mathbf{w}$, and its displacement from the origin is controlled by the bias parameter w_0. Also, the signed orthogonal distance of a general point $\mathbf{x}$ from the decision surface is given by $y(\mathbf{x})/\|\mathbf{w}\|$.

an arbitrary point $\mathbf{x}$ and let $\mathbf{x}_\perp$ be its orthogonal projection onto the decision surface, so that

$$\mathbf{x} = \mathbf{x}_\perp + r\frac{\mathbf{w}}{\|\mathbf{w}\|}. \tag{4.6}$$

Multiplying both sides of this result by $\mathbf{w}^{\mathrm{T}}$ and adding w_0, and making use of $y(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{w}^{\mathrm{T}}\mathbf{x} + w_0$ and $y(\mathbf{x}_\perp) = \mathbf{w}^{\mathrm{T}}\mathbf{x}_\perp + w_0 = 0$, we have

$$r = \frac{y(\mathbf{x})}{\|\mathbf{w}\|}. \tag{4.7}$$

This result is illustrated in Figure 4.1.

As with the linear regression models in Chapter 3, it is sometimes convenient to use a more compact notation in which we introduce an additional dummy 'input' value $x_0 = 1$ and then define $\widetilde{\mathbf{w}} = (w_0, \mathbf{w})$ and $\widetilde{\mathbf{x}} = (x_0, \mathbf{x})$ so that

$$y(\mathbf{x}) = \widetilde{\mathbf{w}}^{\mathrm{T}}\widetilde{\mathbf{x}}. \tag{4.8}$$

In this case, the decision surfaces are D-dimensional hyperplanes passing through the origin of the $D+1$-dimensional expanded input space.

4.1.2 Multiple classes

Now consider the extension of linear discriminants to $K > 2$ classes. We might be tempted be to build a K-class discriminant by combining a number of two-class discriminant functions. However, this leads to some serious difficulties (Duda and Hart, 1973) as we now show.

Consider the use of $K-1$ classifiers each of which solves a two-class problem of separating points in a particular class $\mathcal{C}_k$ from points not in that class. This is known as a *one-versus-the-rest* classifier. The left-hand example in Figure 4.2 shows an

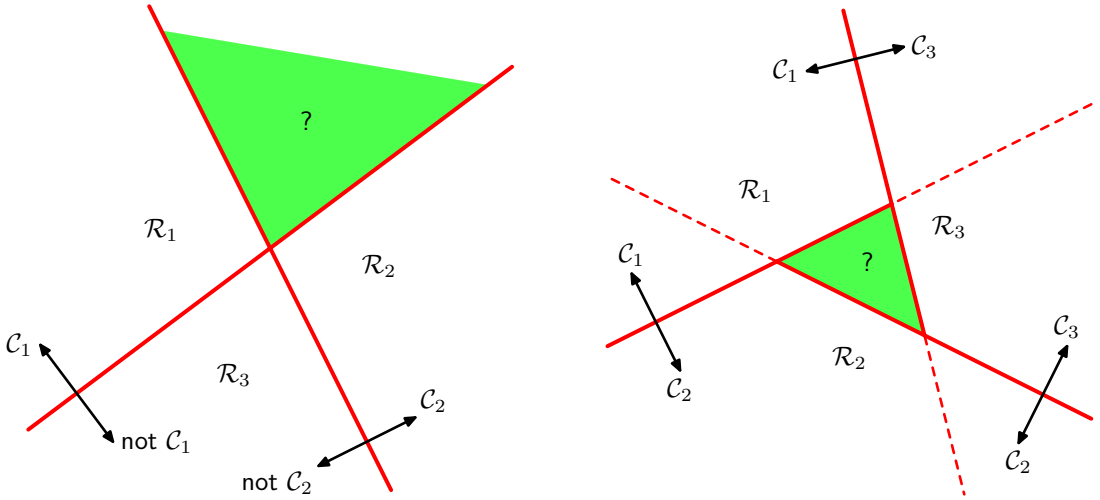


Figure 4.2 Attempting to construct a K class discriminant from a set of two class discriminants leads to ambiguous regions, shown in green. On the left is an example involving the use of two discriminants designed to distinguish points in class $\mathcal{C}_k$ from points not in class $\mathcal{C}_k$. On the right is an example involving three discriminant functions each of which is used to separate a pair of classes $\mathcal{C}_k$ and $\mathcal{C}_j$.

example involving three classes where this approach leads to regions of input space that are ambiguously classified.

An alternative is to introduce $K(K-1)/2$ binary discriminant functions, one for every possible pair of classes. This is known as a *one-versus-one* classifier. Each point is then classified according to a majority vote amongst the discriminant functions. However, this too runs into the problem of ambiguous regions, as illustrated in the right-hand diagram of Figure 4.2.

We can avoid these difficulties by considering a single K-class discriminant comprising K linear functions of the form

$$y_k(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{w}_k^{\mathrm{T}}\mathbf{x} + w_{k0} \tag{4.9}$$

and then assigning a point $\mathbf{x}$ to class $\mathcal{C}_k$ if $y_k(\mathbf{x}) > y_j(\mathbf{x})$ for all $j \neq k$. The decision boundary between class $\mathcal{C}_k$ and class $\mathcal{C}_j$ is therefore given by $y_k(\mathbf{x}) = y_j(\mathbf{x})$ and hence corresponds to a $(D-1)$-dimensional hyperplane defined by

$$(\mathbf{w}_k - \mathbf{w}_j)^{\mathrm{T}}\mathbf{x} + (w_{k0} - w_{j0}) = 0. \tag{4.10}$$

This has the same form as the decision boundary for the two-class case discussed in Section 4.1.1, and so analogous geometrical properties apply.

The decision regions of such a discriminant are always singly connected and convex. To see this, consider two points $\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{A}}$ and $\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{B}}$ both of which lie inside decision region $\mathcal{R}_k$, as illustrated in Figure 4.3. Any point $\widehat{\mathbf{x}}$ that lies on the line connecting $\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{A}}$ and $\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{B}}$ can be expressed in the form

$$\widehat{\mathbf{x}} = \lambda\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{A}} + (1-\lambda)\mathbf{x}_{\mathrm{B}} \tag{4.11}$$